



Beyond the Hype: Where AI Actually Wins in Indie SaaS

A strategic read of 1,000 revenue-generating micro-SaaS startups — testing the AI gold-rush narrative against the numbers.

**AI is now the most crowded category in indie SaaS.
Where should builders and investors actually place their
next bet?**

1,000

startups tracked

197

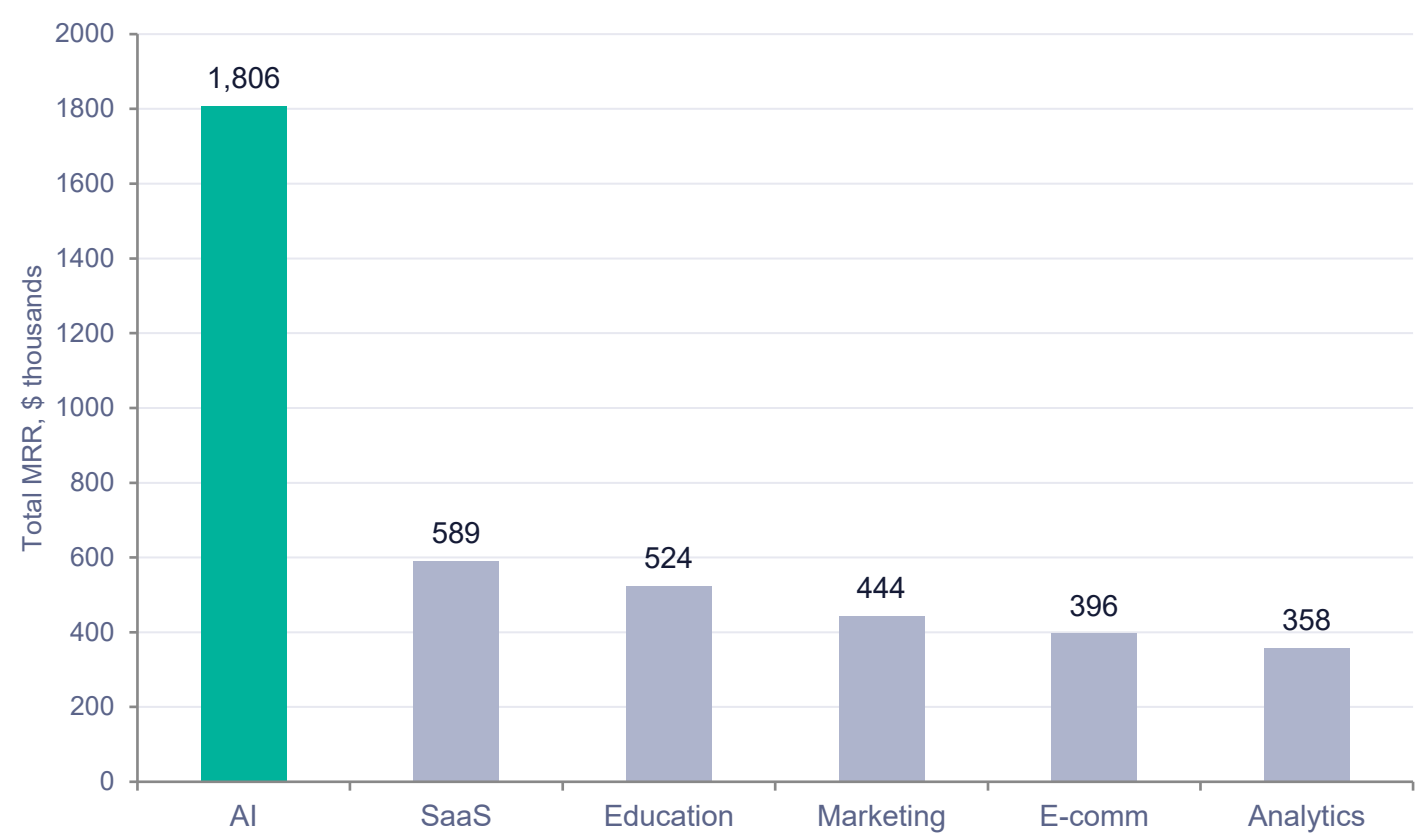
labeled “AI” — the single largest category

12

distinct AI sub-niches once tags are unpacked

By the numbers, AI looks like the winning category

Most startups, most combined revenue — the volume story favors AI.



197

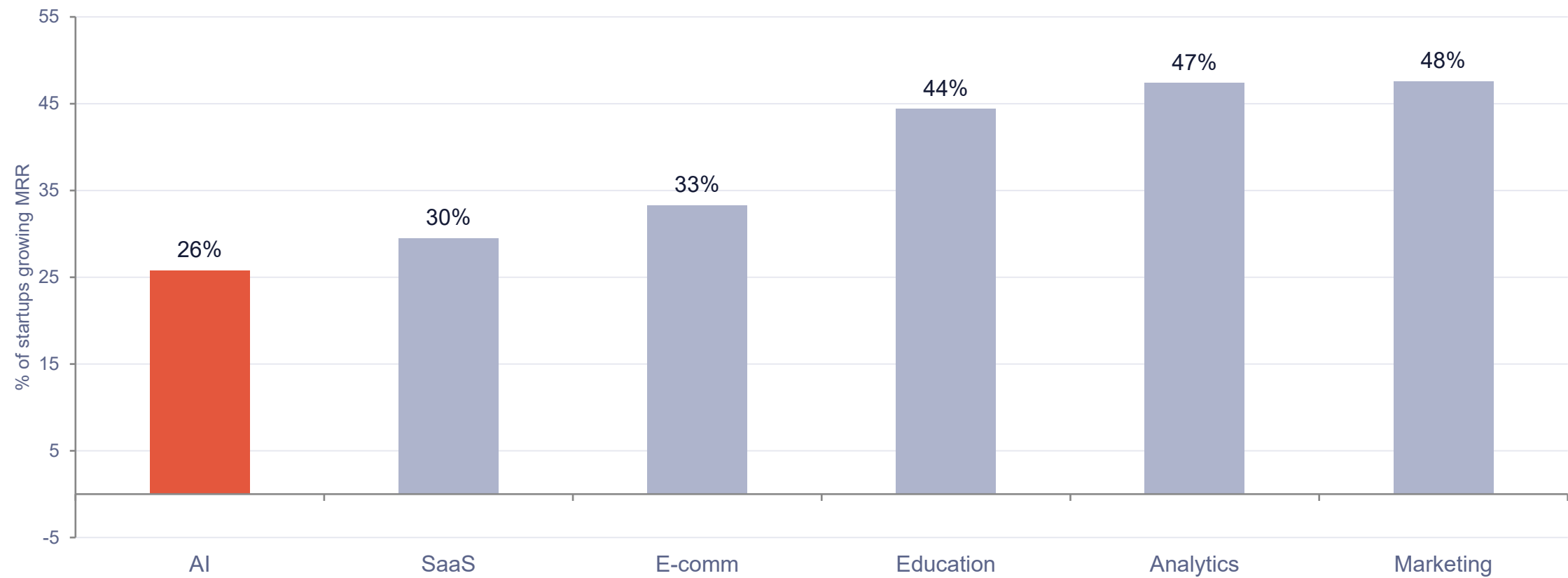
AI startups in the dataset — more than any other labeled category

\$1.81M

combined MRR from AI startups — the highest of any category

But AI has the weakest growth of any major category

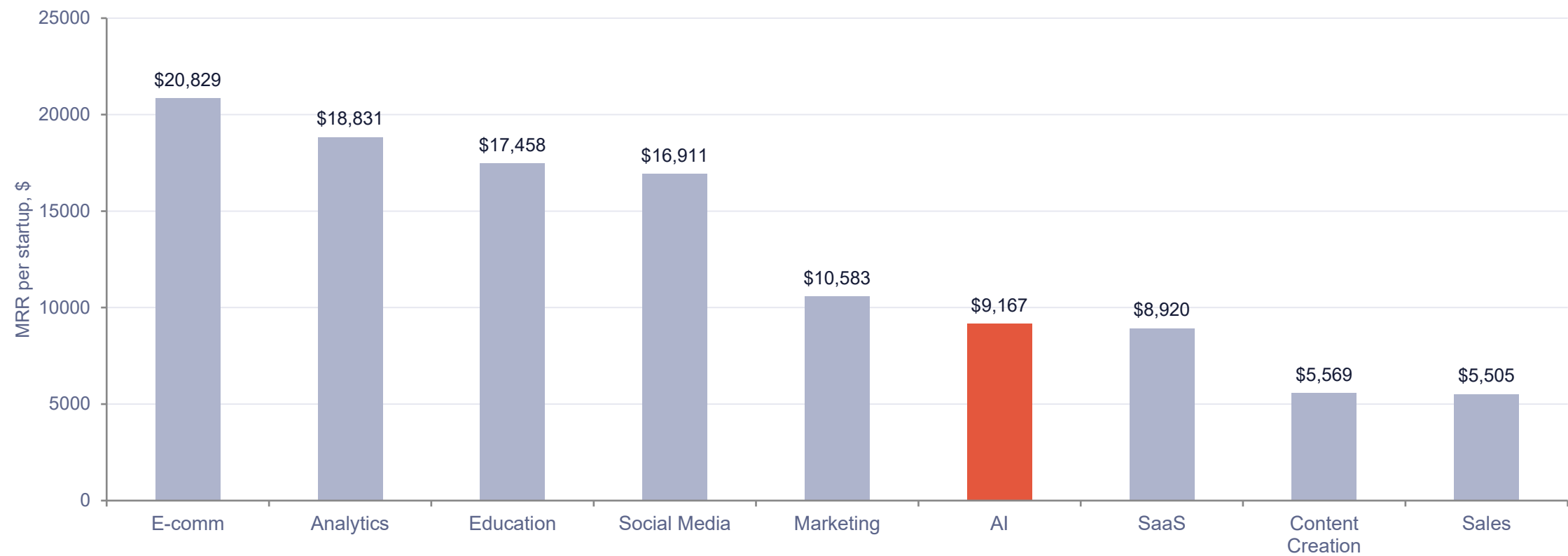
Share of startups with positive 30-day MRR growth, same six categories.



WHY IT MATTERS

The average AI founder earns less than founders elsewhere

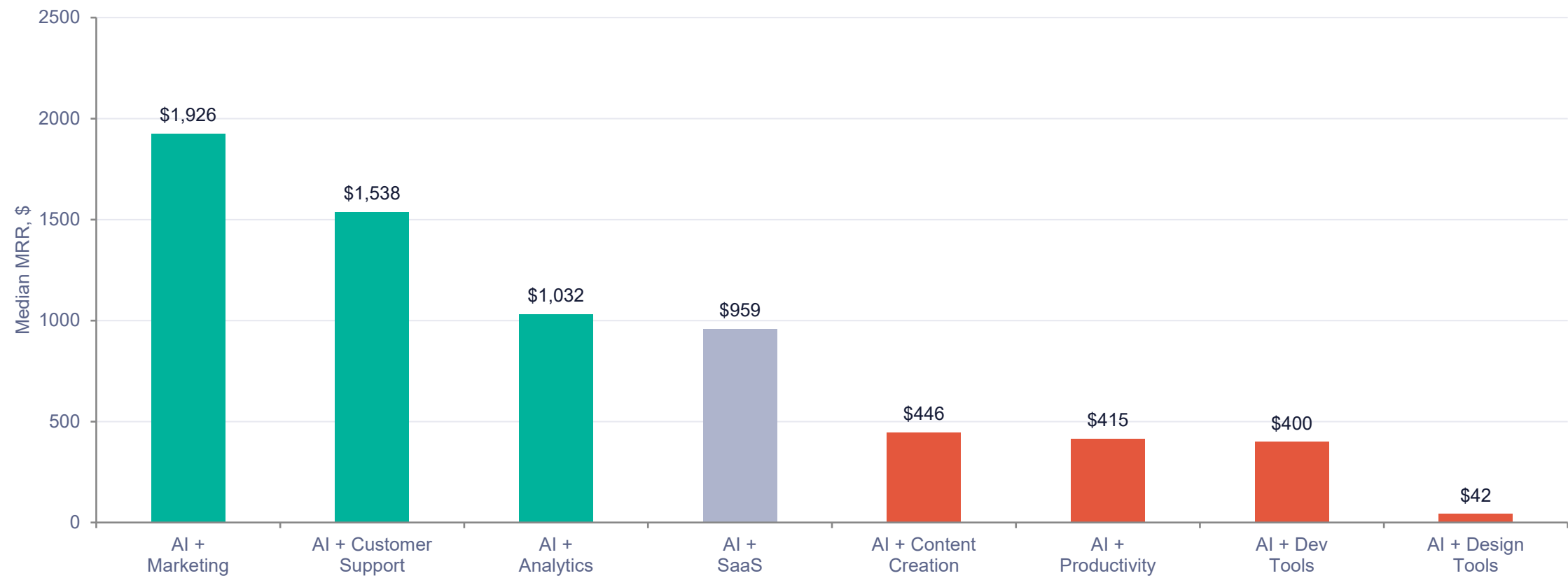
Combined MRR ÷ startup count, by category (min. 10 startups) — a proxy for how much revenue one founder actually captures.



AI ranks 6th of 9 major categories on revenue captured per startup

Not all “AI” is equal — sub-niche is the real variable

Median MRR for AI startups, split by the specific workflow they serve (from co-tagged market labels).



46x spread between the strongest and weakest AI sub-niche shown

The AI Graveyard

Content-creation and design AI tools drew the biggest crowds — and paid out the least.

97

AI + Content Creation startups

median MRR just \$446

31

AI + Design Tools startups

median MRR just \$42

These are the two largest AI sub-niches by founder count — and the two weakest by revenue. Differentiation is the scarce resource here, not the model.

The AI Winners

AI embedded in a specific business workflow monetizes 2–4x better than generic AI tools.

\$1,926

AI + Marketing

51 startups · 4.3x Content Creation

\$1,538

AI + Customer Support

16 startups · 3.4x Content Creation

\$1,032

AI + Analytics

31 startups · 2.3x Content Creation

Median MRR, AI startups tagged with each workflow — all compared against AI + Content Creation (\$446 median).

Two moats an indie AI founder actually controls

Pricing model

\$39

Subscription ARPU

\$19

Freemium ARPU

Among AI startups, subscription pricing earns 2.1x the revenue per user that freemium does.

Content / SEO authority

0.50

Domain Rating ↔ MRR,
within AI startups

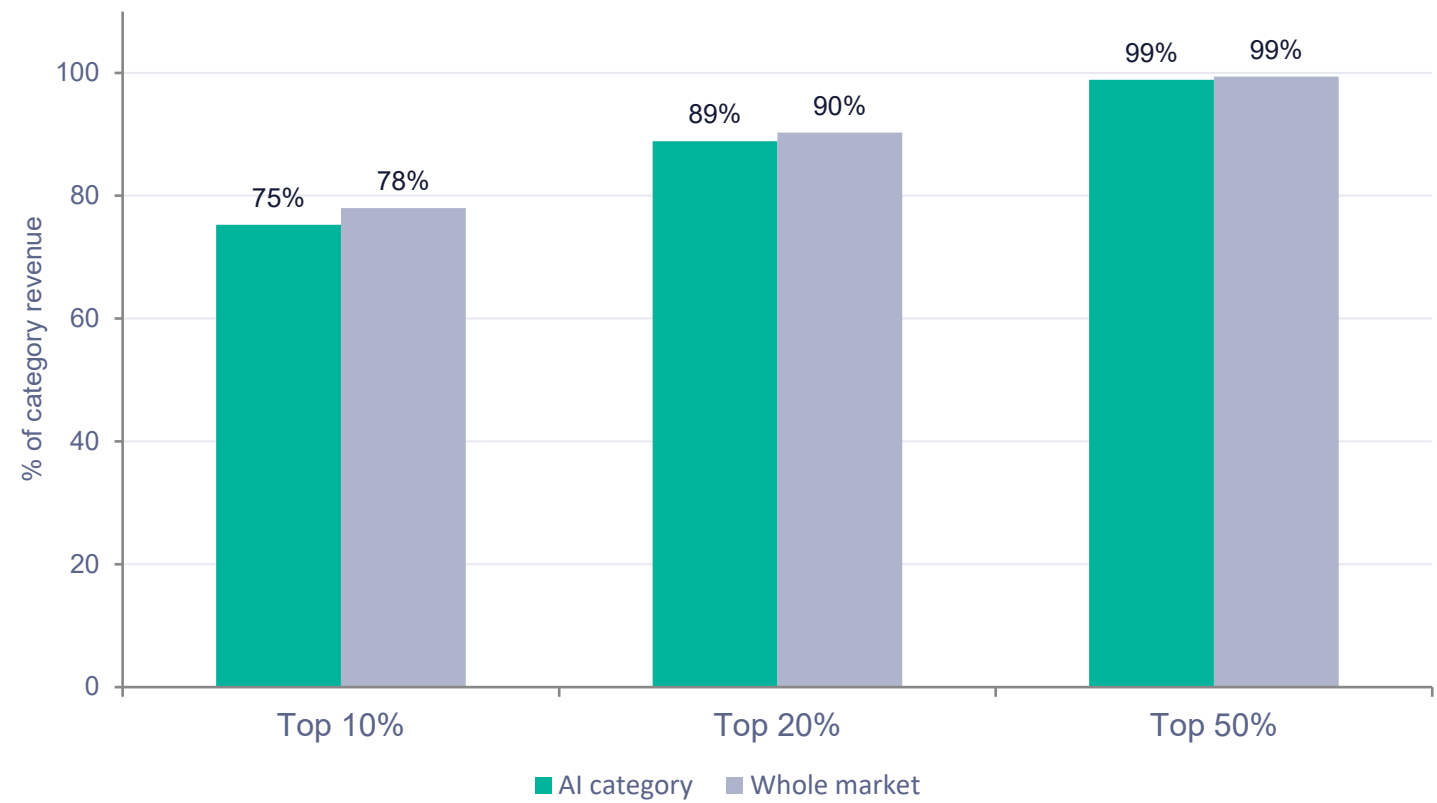
0.40

same correlation,
whole market

Domain authority predicts revenue more strongly inside AI than in the market overall — it's the tie-breaker in a noisy category.

Even the winning niches are a power-law market

Share of revenue held by the top N% of startups, AI vs. the whole market.



20.5x

gap between AI's mean MRR (\$9,167) and its median (\$446)

A handful of breakout winners carry the category average. Plan around the median outcome, not the headline one.

What indie AI builders should do next

1

Skip the wrapper

97 competitors already split a \$446 median outcome in AI content tools. Differentiation there is nearly impossible.

2

Build inside a workflow

AI + Marketing, Customer Support, or Analytics monetizes 2–4x better than generic AI content or design tools.

3

Charge subscription from day one

Subscription pricing earns 2.1x the ARPU of freemium among AI startups — free tiers aren't a growth lever here.

4

Invest in content / SEO authority

Domain Rating is the strongest revenue predictor available to a solo AI founder ($r = 0.50$).

What investors should screen for in AI deals

1

Screen by sub-niche, not the “AI” label

The category tag hides a 46x spread in median MRR across sub-niches — due diligence starts one level deeper.

2

Weight growth over current MRR

Only 25.8% of AI startups are still growing MRR — the lowest share of any major category. Size without momentum is a warning sign.

3

Benchmark against non-AI efficiency

Per-founder revenue in AI (\$9.2K) trails E-comm, Analytics, and Education. Use those categories as the efficiency bar, not AI's own average.

4

Sanity-check any acquisition multiple

Across the broader on-sale dataset, the median asking multiple is ~3.0x trailing revenue — treat higher multiples on small-base AI listings as requiring extra diligence.



AI isn't one bet — it's twelve bets with wildly different odds.

Win by picking the workflow, not the label: go narrow, charge subscription, and build the content authority that makes a small team findable.

Thank you — questions welcome.